

Collaborating with Generative AI in Consumer Culture Research

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Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) has introduced new possibilities for both the creation and analysis of language, which is one key input for consumer culture researchers who analyze qualitative and textual data. How can consumer culture researchers use GenAI to produce insights and work with qualitative data? What are the possibilities and challenges of using these tools? And what are some valuable practices and principles for integrating GenAI into the research process? Building from interviews with researchers who use these tools, the authors identify relevant theoretical, embodied, empirical, and historical contextual dimensions that produce opportunities and challenges for human–AI collaboration. The authors then propose a set of collaborative practices and offer practical guidelines for using GenAI to generate novel and meaningful insights into consumer culture and society.

Keywords: qualitative research, cultural research, text analysis, generative artificial intelligence, agency

Generative AI (GenAI) raises new possibilities as a research tool to enhance human sensemaking and interpretation. Yet, technology is not new to studying culture. Early ethnographers employed pen and pencil to document speech patterns, ceremonial practices, housing patterns, and dress of tribe members and informants (Jones 2010). Malinowski collected these in “field notebooks” that served as aides in recalling these observations to create theories of ceremonial exchange (Roldán 2002). Marcel

Mauss famously never entered the field, preferring to develop insights based on archived studies that used the technology of print (Fournier 2006).

Computers, of course, provide enhanced abilities for collecting, storing, synthesizing, and retrieving information (Ong 1982, 1998). In the early 1960s, researchers began using IBM mainframes to analyze the content of a wide variety of sources, including conversational material, personal documents, dreams, survey responses, literary sources, speeches, and folktales (Stone et al. 1966, 156). Kathleen Carley used early software for counting words to develop insights about similarities and differences across cultures and changes within culture (Carley 1994). While basic tools have been used to count words that are determined a priori in a qualitative textual dataset, classification and topic-modeling tools have been used to identify “topics” based on patterns of co-occurrence in the textual dataset (Berger et al. 2020; Humphreys and Wang 2018; Nelson 2020). Word embedding (e.g., word2vec) and neural network models (e.g., BERT) then take a further step of understanding and more fully incorporating the context of words within the text. In particular, the computer is trained as to the “meaning” of words based on structural patterns in a very large training dataset or corpus (Mikolov et al. 2013a, 2013b).

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Editor: Bernd Schmitt

This article was invited by Editor Bernd Schmitt for our special section on GenAI and Consumer Research and did not go through the journal's standard peer-review process but was subject to an expedited review and revision process.

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<https://doi.org/10.1093/jcr/ucaf014>

Consumer culture researchers have adopted many of these text analysis tools as they have emerged (e.g., Arsel and Bean 2013; Arvidsson and Caliandro 2016; Coskuner-Balli 2020; Ertimur and Coskuner-Balli 2015; Humphreys 2010; Luri, Schau, and Ghosh 2024; Novak and Hoffman 2023). For example, consumer researchers have used approaches such as dictionary-based analysis to understand cultural discourses (Humphreys 2010) and metaphors (Luri et al. 2024), topic models to investigate cultural products (Berger and Packard 2022), and word embedding to study consumer practices (Novak and Hoffman 2023).

Large-language models (LLMs) have a lineage stemming from these other forms of text analysis (figure 1; Ibrahim and Voyer 2024; Than et al. 2024). Building from word-embedding, LLMs simply reverse the process, producing text by predicting the next most probable word and answering queries by retrieving information and putting it into a linguistic structure based on what it has previously learned from the training dataset (Brown et al. 2020; Puntoni et al. 2021). These abilities point to a growing set of possibilities for using LLMs to synthesize and interact with qualitative and textual data in new ways. Conceivably, such analytical processes act as an extension of iterative tacking between data, computer-aided analysis, and human analysis. Just as social scientists have proposed using text analysis to aid cultural research (Carley 1994; Weber 2005), we view GenAI as an additional aid to human analysis and sensemaking of cultural phenomena.

Beyond the existing computational technology that scholars have previously employed, GenAI—by which we mean large language models (LLMs) that are capable of producing language—potentially offers a new technology to integrate into the typical routines of conducting research and gleaning insights about consumer behavior and culture. Yet, GenAI may also have limitations in producing insights and may present challenges as scholars learn how to interact with these new tools. Indeed, the possibilities may also shape our thinking about research and the role that humans play in developing insights about consumer culture, just as Walter Ong suggests

that moving from orality to literacy shaped human thinking and storytelling. We therefore ask: How can consumer culture researchers use GenAI to produce insights and work with qualitative data? What are the possibilities and challenges of using these tools? And what are some valuable practices and principles for integrating GenAI into the research process?

DATA AND METHODOLOGY

Given that practices for incorporating GenAI into consumer culture research are emergent, evolving, and varied, instead of proposing fixed answers to these questions, we conducted interviews with academic and industry researchers who study consumer culture (appendix A). Our goal was to develop empirical insights about what experienced researchers in the field thought about GenAI, understand how they integrated these tools into their research, and to learn what challenges and limitations they found with the technology. Equally, we were interested in the human side of GenAI and sought to learn about the iterative process of researcher and AI collaboration.

We recruited consumer culture researchers who work with qualitative data, consumer researchers and sociologists who use LLMs for text analysis, and industry professionals trained as cultural analysts who work with qualitative data (using pseudonyms to protect anonymity). We also included a negative case (i.e., a researcher who conducts only manual analysis) and sought member checks. Interviews ranged from 47 to 64 minutes (average 56 minutes) and were conducted via video conference. Transcriptions yielded 542 single-spaced pages of text. In addition, to familiarize ourselves with the tools participants mentioned, we used AI tools, watched tutorials, and asked participants to demonstrate uses during interviews. Extended excerpts from interviews can be found in appendix B, table A2.

Following each interview, we created memos to capture emergent themes (Huberman and Miles 1994). Throughout the research process, we discussed how insights from interviews informed our perspectives, aligned with or violated our

FIGURE 1
EVOLUTION OF AUTOMATED TEXT-BASED ANALYSIS



prior assumptions, and compared with existing literature. We also used open coding procedures to generate initial themes across the interviews around potential uses and challenges and to identify practices (Strauss and Corbin 2014). As the analysis evolved, we examined underlying tradeoffs related to the foundations of cultural research and used them to inform our views of the relationship between human researchers and GenAI tools in the research process. We deepened our understanding of these tradeoffs by reading relevant philosophy, research methods, and prior consumer research.

In addition, we employed LLMs both as a basis for comparison to our traditional analytical approach and to interact with and analyze the data. In particular, we used a walled AI sandbox (NCSC 2025) to summarize interviews and to query the data about themes, summaries, and examples of conclusions made by the LLM (web appendix B). We also compared interview summaries generated by the tool against summaries written by one co-author prior to employing the LLM tool. This kind of participant observation and iterative use of GenAI provided additional insight into the usefulness of these tools and triangulation with insights from informants and our own analysis.

TRADEOFFS IN HUMAN-AI RESEARCH COLLABORATION

We organize our framework around understanding the tradeoffs that researchers make when collaborating with GenAI, each based on fundamental differences between humans and GenAI (table 1). While we recognize that GenAI tools will continue to evolve and may be able to take on new research tasks in the future, these tradeoffs capture four enduring and relevant contextual dimensions in consumer culture research: theoretical, embodied, empirical, and historical. The theoretical dimension concerns differences in the purpose and rationale for conducting research. The embodied dimension refers to differences in the lived experience of researchers versus AI. The empirical dimension pertains to differences in what and how human researchers versus computers know, and the historical dimension refers to differences in their temporal perspectives. These contextual dimensions operate across the research process, as cultural research is iterative and recursive (McCracken 1988; Peirce 1903/1934; Sætre and Van de Ven 2021). That is, researchers are continually interpreting and analyzing data as they are collecting them and tacking back and forth between their emergent insights,

TABLE 1
COLLABORATING WITH AI TOOLS IN CONSUMER CULTURE RESEARCH

Tradeoffs related to cultural research	Opportunities to use GenAI (engage)	Challenges that limit potential uses (avoid)
Theoretical context <i>Differences in Agency:</i> Researcher lens as goal-driven perspective (vs. AI "view from nowhere")	Summarizing Summarize surface-level themes with a given set of empirical materials Limiting Summarize prior research with a given set of articles	Theorizing Conduct deep theoretical analysis to generate novel insights
Embodied context <i>Differences in Embodiment:</i> Value of embodied, holistic human experience (vs. composite experience)	Compositing Voice "typical" consumer response Extending Use AI to extend human abilities such as language barriers of researchers and/or informants Querying Investigate AI as a subject in its own right	Faking Generate individual interview data for analysis Misrepresenting Voice consumers unobservable in training data
Empirical context <i>Differences in Epistemology:</i> Deep familiarity with data (vs. unfamiliarity with empirical context)	Dialoguing and Discovering Help researchers dialogue with a known set of data and use AI to discover new themes in data that may have been missed by the researcher Connecting Incorporate multi-modal data and connect cultural discourses between datasets Corroborating Corroborate codings and findings established through other methods	Replacing Replace human cultural analysts (potential to miss emergent themes) Interviewing Use AI as an interviewer/moderator for cultural insights
Historical context <i>Differences in Historical Context:</i> Understanding cultural moments (vs. flattening to universal, ahistorical content)	Accessing Help investigate historical worlds, including hard to access, disappearing, or rare perspectives (e.g., languages)	Speculating Analyze new or emergent cultural practices and meanings

prior assumptions, theory and data triangulation between rounds of data collection. For exposition, we highlight the most pressing opportunities and challenges within each contextual dimension and enumerate the human–AI collaboration practices most related to that dimension (appendix C).

Theoretical Context: Researcher Lens versus AI “View from Nowhere”

The first tradeoff pertains to differences in agency between humans and GenAI. Consumer culture researchers hold clearly positioned points of view, meaning they are directed by theoretical lenses, goals, background intentions, and knowledge that motivate the research (Denzin 1997). In contrast, because LLMs represent a generalized form of language, highly abstracted from one particular text, they present what Lorraine Daston calls the “view from nowhere”—a scientific distance that represents its object as a perspective-less totality (Daston 1992; Daston and Galison 2021; see also Nagel 1986). For this reason, there is a tradeoff in terms of agency—the directed, theoretical rationale and drive for conducting the research versus an abstracted, generalized point of view. For human researchers, insights develop from “friction” between prior assumptions and data that machines purposively lack. Cultural analysts bring their own initial research questions, prior assumptions from immersion in the phenomenon, broad reading of literature, and their own embodied human experiences to the analysis. Apart from its training dataset and encoded algorithms and parameters, GenAI does not have its own questions, assumptions, or goals (Barandiaran and Almendros 2024). While researchers can feed in these motivations through advanced programming and give the tool roles through prompts, the output of LLMs is produced without a specific, independent goal or theoretical perspective in mind.

As such, humans possess relative autonomous agency while computers’ agency is embedded in human design and human interaction in use, what philosophers have called “midtended agency.” For example, one analysis of LLM agency concludes that, “a LLM fails to meet necessary and sufficient conditions for autonomous agency in the light of embodied theories of mind: the individuality condition (it is not the product of its own activity, it is not even directly affected by it), the normativity condition (it does not generate its own norms or goals), and, partially the interactional asymmetry condition (it is not the origin and sustained source of its interaction with the environment)” (Barandiaran and Almendros 2024, 1). However, as these authors note, “ChatGPT should be characterized as an interlocutor or linguistic automaton, a library-that-talks, devoid of (autonomous) agency, but capable to engage performatively on non-purposeful yet purpose-structured and purpose-bounded tasks.” Thus, while LLMs present a

“view from nowhere,” and do not pursue autonomous, goal-driven behavior, when combined with human goal-driven interaction, they achieve a more limited kind of effectuated agency.

Opportunities for Summarizing Data. Consumer culture researchers carefully weigh this basic difference in agency when assessing opportunities to collaborate with AI for analysis. The “view from nowhere” means that LLMs have impressive abilities to summarize a large body of text and synthesize it for researchers. For example, one industry researcher notes that using AI is efficient for aggregating interviews to provide a basic summary (table A2, T1) and argues that while similar aims were previously achieved with “highlighting and post-it notes,” GenAI provides affordances for summarizing “high-level themes” quickly and effectively in ways that are tractable to managers and researchers. Several of our informants similarly referred to LLM tools like ChatGPT as glorified “word calculators,” and noted their efficiency. In this way, researchers thought of GenAI as a very competent assistant for gathering and summarizing common themes.

Opportunities for Conceptualization Through Limiting. Participants also described using GenAI for a practice we call “limiting”—uploading a curated set of academic articles to an LLM tool and then using it to better understand key concepts and theories, conceptualize research questions, identify gaps in prior research, and understand how their investigation might fit with relevant concepts. One academic researcher, for example, discusses using AI assistants during the conceptualization phase of research to summarize different theoretical perspectives and draw contrasts amongst them (T2). Yet, he also reports that asking the LLM about a concept without limiting produces results that are “too course” and that results are best when a limited set of articles, around 25, are uploaded. Several informants reported the usefulness of tools like ChatGPT, Notebook, or Research Rabbit for aiding with preliminary literature reviews and related tasks.

Challenges for Deep Theorizing. While GenAI produces coherent top-line summaries (Schmitt 2024), cultural analysts often generate *insights* through the friction between the data and the researcher’s prior assumptions, understandings of theory, (non)resonant experiences, and/or evolving research questions. While prompting can offer points of friction to improve GenAI’s analysis, deeper interpretations will not spontaneously emerge. As Mattias, an academic researcher notes, “The tool won’t ask research questions by itself. It wouldn’t select contexts, and it wouldn’t be interested in anything. It’s just a tool.” That is, researchers are goal-driven to seek out cultural insights that resonate with a theoretical perspective and have meaning within a system of conducting research for a particular purpose.

For example, consider the differences between the AI-generated summary of an interview we conducted alongside our own summary (table 2), written prior to using AI (and without the anticipation of using it).

The AI summary contains descriptions of the basic points from the interview, but a marked distinction exists from what is recorded in the researcher summary. The latter comes from an informed cultural analyst with knowledge and experience that form the basis for questions or assumptions that create friction in our reading and interpretation of the data. It draws from theoretical perspectives (e.g., the use of the word “dialogic”) that are relevant to the research goal (i.e., understanding the collaborative research process). It also tacks between theory and data iteratively (e.g., “lacks embodied experience—‘context, nuance, texture’”). The excerpts chosen as examples in the researcher summary move the interpretation forward. In particular, Johann described cultural analysts’ intense “analytical work” and “embodied experience,” which we found to be productive ideas for looking at and linking to other insights and theories.

Embodied Context: The Value of Embodied, Human Experience versus Composite Experience

The next tradeoff comes from the ways in which humans and AI are differently embodied. As Merleau-Ponty points out, sensing is different from knowing (1945/2013). In

sensing, humans draw from a holistic, embodied experience that, as many philosophers have argued, is prior to, and emerges with, cognition (Husserl 1900/2008; Johnson 2015, 2017; Kant 1781/1998). “Sensing is that living communication with the world that makes it present to us as the familiar place of our life. The perceived object and the perceiving subject owe their thickness to sensing” (61). Although GenAI can be trained on representations of sense experience and can therefore synthetically report embodied experiences, it cannot directly or autonomously sense the world (Dreyfus 1992).

In addition, each human individual has a linked biography of embodied experience (Kant 1781/1998). This biographical identity both shapes how researchers see the world and merits protection when participating in research. Equally, GenAI has a “biography” comprised of its training data and parameters, and our informants noted the importance of understanding this biography to interpret the output. Judging the elements that constituted the interlocutor is necessary to determine what it can and cannot “voice”. We should also note that when humans iteratively use embedded tools like computers, there is a sense in which the distinction between human and computer is not always clearly delineated, and indeed technologies can shape our perception and abilities by offering different affordances that enable different ways of experiencing the world (Benjamin 1935/1969; Haraway 1987; McLuhan 1994).

TABLE 2
SUMMARY VERSUS INTERPRETATION MEMO

GenAI summary of interview	Researcher summary of interview
Johann is skeptical about using AI, particularly tools like ChatGPT, in qualitative research. He differentiates between quantitative and qualitative research, arguing that while AI may assist in analyzing quantitative data, it falls short when it comes to understanding the complexities of qualitative research. Johann believes that the qualitative research process involves a non-reductionist approach, which requires human interpretation and understanding that AI cannot replicate.	Very low-tech process. Analysis and interpretation are dialogic—in conversation with co-authors, but also with theory and the literature to help with sense making and trying out his thinking. Would he do this with AI? Yes, he tried this, but it was not as interesting as talking with another person: “Answers are so cookie cutter. . . rather superficial. . . mimics in a cheap, unreflective way, and it spits out these sound bites.”
He expresses concerns about the credibility of AI-generated data, stating that they lack the richness and context derived from true human experiences. Furthermore, Johann emphasizes the importance of the researcher’s role in conducting qualitative research, highlighting that the interpretive understanding that comes from a manual, thoughtful process cannot be easily replaced by AI.	Interviewing AI versus human: ChatGPT lacks embodied experience—“context, nuance, texture” (25 minutes). Comparisons between a human’s biographical experience and how AI generates content. Data that come from a “life lived” are not comparable to the “lumped together kind of language” from synthetic respondents (38 minutes). People underestimate the theory development process and the “analytical work” it takes (32 minutes). Ethical concerns about feeding interview data into AI, so has not tried. He doubts AI could develop a theoretical framework that would match what researchers do. ChatGPT gives you “coffee table book style” of themes rather than a complex and sophisticated analysis (35 minutes).
Overall, he views the attempts to use AI as a means of generating qualitative data or analysis as inadequate, noting that ethical concerns also play a role in his reluctance to embrace these technologies fully.	For other types of analysis like topic modeling, he doesn’t trust AI—“I don’t know what it’s doing. It’s like a black box.” Cultural research is “non-reductionist, intentionally” (42 minutes). Johann noted using AI to generate synthetic interviews is “ridiculous” and that generating interviews is also just unethical (fake data).

Opportunities for Compositing Consumer Perspectives. From this background, many informants spoke about their experiences using AI to produce a synthetic composite of data. AI's ability to synthesize multiple, individual biographies presents the possibility of voicing a "typical" consumer from the data. One academic researcher in sociology explains that she regards GenAI as a synthesis or composite of multiple perspectives, similar to a character in a novel or movie (E1). In this way, output can be used to "capture schemas" which are fundamental to work in cultural sociology. From this perspective, LLMs are a useful tool for synthesizing a large and varied set of interview or media data and presenting the most common cultural schemas in an efficient way.

Similarly, professionals found synthetic audiences useful for message testing, again, with a careful eye to the "biography" of the AI, as constituted by its training data set and parameters. Arya, an industry researcher, explains that synthetic audiences are "only as good as their data," (E2) and that researchers require a sound understanding of the training data to assess the value of GenAI and its potential uses (see also Ibrahim and Voyer 2024). Some academics even go on to conclude that tools like ChatGPT are not appropriate for serious academic use at all due to the opacity in their training datasets (E3).

Opportunities for Extending Human Capabilities. GenAI can also be used to overcome linguistic barriers of the embodied human researcher or subject. For example, although LLM performance may be unequal across languages (He et al. 2024; Khondaker et al. 2024; Li et al. 2024), LLaMa 3 supports English, Spanish, French, German, Italian, Portuguese, Dutch, Russian, Chinese, Japanese, and Korean (Touvron et al. 2023). In addition, some LLMs may be a better fit with some languages than others (e.g., Deepseek and Mandarin). The ability to collect and interpret data from participants who speak different languages undoubtedly enables better access to a wider range of consumers, making new perspectives more accessible to researchers, even if cultural and linguistic context may still be missing or indeterminant (Koc 2025; Quine 2013).

Challenges of Faking Individual Consumer Perspectives. Despite proposed uses for generating synthetic transcripts (Arora, Chakraborty, and Nishimura, 2025), consumer culture researchers did not see value in generating AI transcripts for analysis in lieu of individual interviews. All our participants felt it did not make sense to use AI as a tool to approximate *a biographical human's* experience, especially without context about that person's life. As one academic researcher who generated AI transcripts for comparison purposes said, "[Chat]GPT is as good as a boring person...where the respondent just isn't saying a lot of interesting things...I found it very difficult

to say that this is data that gives me any substantial insight" (Mattias). Participants often mentioned the spontaneity and uniqueness present in human interviews. One academic researcher, for example, notes that in an interview, humans adjust their language to the speech context, including power dynamics between the speaker and listener and the objective environment: "Yeah, we take into account the social. There's our own psychology. There's the physical environment, context, the object environment." Considering these dynamics explains distinctions between human and synthetic AI respondents. As Mattias continues, "The difference is that real people...are socialized into a live world. They grow up in this setting. They have experience based on their surroundings and environments, and you can meet them in a coffee shop, and you can see how they drink, and how they sit, and how they speak...and you will assess everything that's going on in their lives...Try to really understand the person with the background where they're coming from. You cannot do that with ChatGPT." Human participants are situated within their own cultural contexts with their own embodied experiences. Cultural analysts use the background and contextual details within individual interviews to help situate participants within their lifeworld and broader cultural milieu (Pollio, Henley, and Thompson 1997). This helps the researcher make sense of that human's life experiences and understand how they articulate the connections among them.

Conversely, the contextual details provided by GenAI may be artificially based on typical arrangements of language meant to simulate the way humans construct a story or explanation, but are often devoid of cultural meaning. Johann, an academic researcher, echoes this sentiment, noting that ChatGPT lacks embodied experience. Interview data from a human come from a "life lived" that is not comparable to the "lumped together kind of language" from synthetic respondents. Contrasting human interviews with experiments in "interviewing" AI, Johann says "They [human interviews] were more embodied experience. I mean, I'm not a phenomenologist...And I don't want to be misunderstood here as like, 'oh, the authentic human experience! The only thing that matters.' But it really does. If you haven't really done this thing, and you haven't really kind of experienced it...[ChatGPT can't]...like, just emulate. So the context, the nuance, the texture, everything that comes from a person's real life and sort of context within...is so much more complex...than anything I've seen from ChatGPT."

When using synthetic audiences for industry, researchers also noted limitations with "interviewing" synthetic subjects seeking cultural insights. As Ash explains, data from human informants tend to be "messier" than the synthesized output of an LLM and humans miss the "light bulb moments" of discovery. Ash continues, "And if you're fabricating that stuff, ...you miss some of the really

fascinating things that are yet to come that you can only find by observing people in their home, or watching them in a moment of tension or engaging with communities in nightclubs or cafes. . . none of which there is precedent for on the Internet. So where? Where can AI find that stuff? Which is why I think AI is a great tool, but it can't ever be the sole solution" (E4). In this sense, the fact that indexical details are missing makes the research inauthentic at best (Grayson and Martinec 2004) and false, at worst. At base, the researchers we interviewed did not view generated transcripts as a valid substitute for empirical work or empirical truth. The fact that synthetic respondents cannot experience the corporeal, contradictory, emotional messiness of a human life restricts its possibilities to generate interpretable data that resonate.

Challenges of Misrepresenting Unobserved Voices.

Given that GenAI is limited by its own biography, researchers expressed caution when using AI to voice marginalized consumers or develop insights where training data may be insufficient. One industry researcher articulates this challenge by noting that some groups of consumers are under-represented in datasets in general and that attempting to draw conclusions about them via AI is—given the limitations in the training data—doubly harmful (E5); not only are views of marginalized consumers less represented in textual data, but these under-representations are further compounded by mis-representing them with AI tools. Importantly, then, researchers cannot draw conclusions about unobserved data—that is, conversations or viewpoints that are neither available nor well-represented in the public domain, nor specifically introduced through training data. For this reason, researchers stressed the need for alignment between the AI's biography and the research question or topic of study, even suggesting that this fit should be evaluated in the review process. For example, one academic researcher notes the limitations of AI tools in producing discourse outside of their training set, such as what people might say privately to a therapist (E6). While informal use of AI may be fine in these contexts, the academic researcher notes, "if I'm a reviewer or an AE looking at a paper that their entire case is built on that, I'm going to look for more, for some human corroborating evidence." Close examination and transparency of the training data are required for cultural approaches, which is why the "black box" platforms (e.g., ChatGPT), in which the training data are relatively obscure, are limited in their utility.

Opportunities for Querying AI as a Subject. Despite reservations with using AI to voice unobserved consumers, researchers encouraged studying AI in its own right, querying an LLM trained broadly on many types of cultural materials to better understand how we might use it as cultural researchers, as Kathryn articulates (E7). Noting that

transformer models on which generative AI is built embed cultural and social biases, she advocates using them to study these biases, while acknowledging the limitations of using them to "explain the underlying social system that produces them" (E7). Thus, it makes sense to continually study AI as a cultural object, seeking a better understanding of how it configures its world and mapping its interactions with humans and other objects. As we will later discuss, AI presents meaningful possibilities for exploring historical perspectives that may be otherwise inaccessible or lost.

Empirical Context: Deep Familiarity versus Unfamiliarity with Empirical Context

The third tradeoff comes from epistemological differences between AI and humans. We simply know different things and have different ways of knowing. Whereas GenAI can account for a vast set of textual material and use it as context, humans have a more embodied, narrow, and perhaps deeper set of "training data." This means that humans have a different type of familiarity with the empirical context being studied and engage in the process of tacking between data and theory through processes of abduction and induction, not just deduction (Peirce 1903/1934). Due to these epistemological differences, GenAI may emphasize output that is out of keeping with what a human observer would consider relevant knowledge (Campo-Ruiz 2025).

On the one hand, LLM's decontextualization from a specific cultural context or community under investigation can help researchers step outside their assumptions by presenting novel relationships, meanings, and concepts that may not occur to them because of how they are positioned. On the other hand, this empirical decontextualization can also present a limitation for researchers interested in understanding the rich nature of their context, strategically selecting informants, and asking specific, directed questions to human participants. Here researchers noted it was important to fill in the gaps with knowledge from the empirical context.

Opportunities for Dialoguing and Discovering with a Known Set of Data. Many informants noted the importance of being familiar with their data. For example, one common practice was to use LLMs to dialogue with an interview or set of interviews by feeding the transcript into a protected sandbox (to ensure privacy) and then querying the tool on underlying themes, opinions, and summaries of the informant's perspective on the topic under investigation. These investigations seemed to take the form of iterative human–technology interactions in which the computational analysis produced output for human sense-making and the human then conducted further computational analysis after interpreting the output. Kathryn

explains that while researchers often use computational methods to study large-scale patterns, they can also make the analytical choice to “zoom in” on negative cases, explore heterogeneity, and evaluate smaller, niche patterns. “We want the islands of difference. . . . And so this ability to zoom in and out is exactly what computational methods allow us to do. Large language models are a little tricky because it all gets garbled into one thing right. So we have to approach it with a lot of care” (EP1). In this way, analysts use GenAI to get closer to the data through queries and, in some cases, provoke new insights. Just as the tool can create distance from the data (by summarizing), the human analyst, as Kathryn observes, can manipulate the technology to “zoom in” on particular aspects of the data. For example, one use that arose in our interactions with GenAI and that participants reported was to ask the tool for common themes and then to query it on the quotations underlying that theme (web appendix C). This allowed us, as researchers, to understand both the conceptual takeaway and the empirical evidence to support it. Further, because the tools can draw from a large dataset, researchers can use them to gain better recall of relevant data from informants that may be overlooked due to the attentional limitations of human researchers.

GenAI’s lack of empirical context also presents the opportunity to potentially discover themes that may otherwise be missed in the data, and, with researcher direction, to amplify less prominent voices in the data. These “islands of difference,” as Kathryn calls them, can provoke meaningful insights that may be buried in the data. Another academic researcher explains that she will take a quick look at the machine synthesis and use it for inspiration (EP2). Despite these clear advantages, researchers also stressed the importance of evaluating the LLM output in light of familiarity with the underlying content and empirical context.

Opportunities for Connecting Between Multi-Level Datasets. Along with this use of AI to solicit data examples and discover new themes, researchers also mentioned using tools for automating part of the coding process and for relating cultural discourses in media with interview data. Depending on the abilities of the LLM, archival data can come in different, non-textual media such as image, video, or audio. Just as prior work has used dictionary-based analysis to link cultural discourses with interviews and consumer practices (Arsel and Bean 2013; Humphreys 2010), GenAI can be used to connect discourses in archival documents or other sources with individual interviews. For example, a tool like MAXQDA or Atlas.ti can be trained with archival documents to understand cultural codes and schemas and then suggest codes when analyzing other forms of data such as interviews. Despite this ability, as Jason notes “the AI kind of is built into Atlas.ti. . . if you

ask it [to generate a code list], it just produces like 10,000 random words. . . it’s so useless. . . The problem is, it doesn’t have a lot of context. . . . So much of it is just extraneous because it lacks the context that if you were to use it in a GPT like you’d be able to provide more context, and it would do a better job.”

Opportunities for Corroborating Codings. Participants also mentioned the use of LLMs for corroborating coding, using the tool as an additional judge as one would in content analysis. Serge notes: “You give it a spreadsheet with a bunch of fields that each have a text that you wanted to analyze. And you say, how emotional was this person? Tell me on a scale of one to 7. . . Explain your thinking. So you can basically treat it like a human judge of open ended language. And it does a great job.” Depending on the cultural approach and the research design, some researchers felt comfortable using GenAI as an additional corroborator of themes and codes. Given the right training data, LLMs are potentially useful for coding even relatively complex concepts. Than et al. (2024) show that LLMs can code a concept like inequality in news media with precisions ranging from an average of 68 to 71.5, depending on if the researcher supplies a definition. Most surprisingly, the LLM did *worse* when a human provided a definition than with no definition or an LLM-provided definition.

Challenges of Replacing Human Analysts. Novel cultural insights can also emerge as the researcher gets deeper into the empirical context. These often come during the tedium of conducting research (e.g., transcribing, meeting informants) or through frustrations and inefficiencies in the process. These are hard to anticipate. What researchers sometimes miss when using GenAI is the emergent aspects of research. GenAI may code textual data more efficiently than humans, but ceding the coding process entirely to AI may push consumer culture researchers further away from—rather than closer to—the data. Because LLMs lack deep immersion in the empirical context, there is the potential to miss spontaneous points of departure that drive new insights. As such, ensuring that human researchers are still making sense of the data and maintaining deep familiarity is critical to mitigate this risk. One industry researcher, for instance, noted how critically their analysis depends on direct observations and detecting what is unusual or interesting (EP3). Thus, by relying exclusively on computational output, researchers risk missing emergent themes. As discussed, research is a goal-directed endeavor where less common, but important and novel observations drive insights. If only relying on the tool for summation, one’s insights can become relatively “flat”, unexciting, and “boring” precisely because they come from algorithms guided by probability (i.e., what is the next most likely word given a certain training set). In this sense, machines are not a replacement for human analysts because human

researchers have a greater sense of the empirical context in which the cultural data were collected and an eye for what insights might be novel or interesting from a cultural perspective. This emergent process in analysis also exists when researchers are selecting informants, sampling for theoretical coverage, including negative cases, formulating questions, or other considerations that come with deep knowledge of the empirical context.

Challenges of Interviewing with AI as Moderator.

Although some have noted the potential for AI to serve as an interviewer or moderator (Arora et al. 2025), several of our informants raise its limitations for gaining cultural insights. One industry researcher observes that the best kind of qualitative analysis involves being sensitive to the context and observing consumers and families over an extended period of time, actively adapting to the context. In doing so, “you almost become an extended part of their world for a little while, and they trust you as custodians of their story” (EP4). Researcher skill for observing tensions between theory and data and vigilance for opportunities to probe comes from ways of knowing that are natural for humans but may be foreign to AI moderators. In sum, our participants felt that differences in what humans and AI know—and even their ways of knowing—lead to tradeoffs regarding empirical context. While there are possibilities to leverage the vast textual knowledgebase of AI, there is also valuable contextual knowledge that human researchers bring to the process.

Historical Context: Understanding Cultural Moments versus Flattening to Ahistorical Context

The final tradeoff considers differences in accounting for historical context. Cultural data are situated, not only in individual, embodied experience, but also in historical context (Hall 2016; Holt 2004). That historical context—as a collection of ideas, meanings, and practices bound by time periods and socio-political moments—helps cultural researchers interpret consumer thoughts and behavior, and indeed is often the focus of investigation (Askegaard and Linnet 2011).

Because LLMs synthesize data over large expanses of time, historical specificity can become obscured or “flattened.” This flattening can also mask cultural differences across communities, national cultures, social classes, races, or gender. The tradeoffs here pertain to cultural analysts’ reliance on historical context to challenge, extend, or build new theory, whereas GenAI’s homogenization of historical context puts these types of insights at risk.

Opportunities for Accessing Historical or Disappearing Worlds. Researchers can attempt to overcome historical flattening by training and querying LLMs to prompt more

sensitivity to historical context. For example, one academic from sociology describes the potential for using GenAI for comparative historical analysis. Because language is historically contextual, she notes, dictionaries that represent linguistic and cognitive dimensions like concreteness (Brysbaert et al. 2014) change over time. One use, she argues, could be to train GenAI tools on historical data to create historically relevant dictionaries rather than dictionaries relevant only to contemporary language (H1). Taking on this task would require careful training of the model with archival materials from that historical time period to provide the LLM with the necessary context to assess meaning.

Further considering historical context, researchers have used LLMs to preserve languages that may be disappearing (Koc 2025). For example, some researchers have trained GenAI on Khoisan languages in Africa, achieving accuracy rates of 85% (Ajuzieogu 2022). The research, however, notes the challenges of preserving historical and cultural context as well as phonetic aspects of the language (e.g., clicking) and concerns of data sparsity with languages that have fewer than 1,000 speakers. As such, using GenAI to voice historical perspectives and preserve language is an inspiring possibility, but the practice remains somewhat speculative and comes with significant challenges in maintaining cultural fidelity.

Challenges of Speculating About Emergent Cultural Phenomena. A lack of situated, historical context can also limit GenAI’s understanding of newly emergent cultural phenomena, practices, language, and associations. Consumer culture researchers select contexts that reveal boundary conditions of existing theory, map out the dimensions of new cultural constructs, or trace the evolution of practices (Price, Moisio, and Arnould 2024). Speaking to the importance of relevance in the current cultural moment in analysis, Ash notes that brands are part of culture, and their success depends on cultural relevance, which is continually changing (H2). These new developments, they argue, cannot be easily produced by AI: “culture is messy, and culture happens at the fringes and culture happens on the streets and in people’s homes and is so embedded in behavior and rituals.” Using GenAI has limits for understanding cultural practices that are emergent and new. Because AI’s historical lens is based on prior associations, new associations may be challenging for it to interpret and identify.

PRINCIPLES AND GUIDELINES FOR COLLABORATING WITH AI

Consumer culture researchers’ collaboration practices with AI are evolving, and there is considerable variation in researcher norms, knowledge, and capability. Despite the

variability and uncertainty about future practices, we outline a practical framework that details researchers' collaboration practices during different stages of the research process and offer four general principles with related practical guidelines based on the practices uncovered in our findings (table 3): transparency, provenance, privacy, and verisimilitude.

Guideline 1: Document GenAI Collaboration in the Research Process for Transparency

Methodological transparency is paramount in order to understand how and when researchers collaborated with GenAI throughout the research process. For practices like summarizing, compositing, and dialoguing, for example, it is helpful to understand what tools were used to synthesize perspectives and pull examples from the dataset. Just as consumer culture researchers document the use of other tools and practices in their research (e.g., coding), knowing when and how AI tools were employed sheds light onto the methodology for analyzing data. To address this priority, we suggest describing each stage of the research where GenAI was used, including providing example prompts and output (web appendices B and C). For example, researchers can report example prompts as one might offer examples of interview questions. While it is important to avoid overly onerous or detailed reporting of informal AI use, it is helpful to know the substantive ways that AI was used in the research. For example, if a tool was used to create codes or return examples in the dataset, this is valuable methodological context for understanding the research and as a model to other researchers. The aim of such reporting is methodological transparency and pedagogy rather than replication.

Guideline 2: Report the Provenance of the Training Data and Include Model Documentation

Consumer culture researchers should attend to and report provenance of the GenAI model's training data and other model specifics. While provenance is important for nearly all practices, it may be particularly valuable to interpreting findings when researchers practice extending, querying, and accessing. To assess its potential uses and situate the data within the cultural context, researchers need to understand the training data—its origins, transformations, time periods, and contents. For example, some academic tools and industry proprietary tools provide descriptions of the training data, including the age of the data, which consumer segments they represent, and other basic information. Understanding training data provenance helps researchers not only assess potential claims but also evaluate limitations of the data and interpretations. Noting the AI model and training data is also helpful to assess the role

of hyperparameters and other model attributes in shaping the output.

Guideline 3: Protect the Privacy of Embodied Research Participants

The researchers we interviewed expressed concerns about the ethics of using GenAI tools that may violate privacy. Practices that involve uploading materials collected from human subjects are particularly relevant when addressing privacy. Due to the nature of qualitative data that potentially contain explicit and implicit identifying information, consumer culture researchers bear additional responsibility to protect the privacy of study participants, as aligned with ethics review boards and human subject protections. As such, researchers should consider how protections are guaranteed, report these in the research, and communicate to participants how their data will be used and protected. For this, many of our participants suggested using walled AI “sandboxes,” LLMs that did not use inputted data for further training and where data could be hosted on a local computer (Gemma). Understandably, hosting an LLM on one's own computer may be too resource intensive for many researchers. However, institutions such as universities and associations may provide walled AIs for faculty and student use (e.g., Microsoft Copilot for education). In terms of data ethics, some researchers also noted that they preferred using an LLM trained on publicly available data sources to those that likely have proprietary training sources like ChatGPT (Brown et al. 2020).

Guideline 4: Ensure Verisimilitude in Findings Based on GenAI

Assessments of verisimilitude are essential when considering consumer culture findings that employ GenAI. Practices such as summarizing and compositing depend on the fidelity of insights to the underlying data and benefit from providing examples side-by-side with aggregations. In addition, AI tools have been observed to return false factual information, or “hallucinate” when asked for particular citations or historical occurrences, and so researchers should use caution when using GenAI for conceptualization or other tasks that require indexical precision. Consumer culture researchers should continually evaluate how GenAI tools might shape their interpretations to ensure they resonate with participants' lived experiences and cultural contexts. Here, it is important to provide both interpretation and evidence from the underlying raw data to illustrate. Further, researchers can ensure verisimilitude through the common practice of triangulating across data sources and researcher interpretations (Arnould and Epp 2006; Belk et al. 1989).

TABLE 3
RESEARCH PRINCIPLES AND GUIDELINES FOR COLLABORATING WITH GENAI

Research stage	Researcher–AI collaboration practices		Principle	Checklist
Literature review	Researcher role: Upload a curated set of articles and use them to conceptualize key concepts and gaps in the literature	Limiting AI role: Summarize a theory or body of research, identify differences between concepts	Transparency	Describe interactions with AI at the conceptualization stage of the research
Data generation/ collection	Researcher role: Upload set of empirical data (e.g., transcripts, scraped data, researcher memos)	Compositing AI role: Produce responses of a “composite” consumer from data	Provenance	Include documentation on the training set of the tool, if available
	Researcher role: Design and iterate research instruments to make data more accessible	Extending AI role: Translate instruments and data to extend researchers’ embodied abilities (e.g., overcome language barriers)	Transparency	Describe which AI tools were used to composite consumers or translate materials
	Researcher role: Ask questions of AI to learn how the tool operates using its default training dataset	Querying AI role: Respond to researcher queries		
Data analysis and interpretation	Researcher role: Upload set of empirical data (e.g., transcripts, scraped data, researcher memos)	Summarizing AI role: Summarize surface-level themes	Privacy	Use a walled-AI assistant to prevent breaches of confidentiality and protect participant privacy
	Researcher role: Upload set of empirical data (e.g., transcripts, scraped data, researcher memos); query on themes that may have been missed	Discovering AI role: Generate bottom-up analysis to discover new themes and to ensure researcher interpretations reflect overall themes	Transparency	Describe which AI tools were used to summarize, discover, dialogue, connect, or corroborate (web appendix C)
	Researcher role: Upload collected data and ask analytical questions (e.g., negative cases, quotes)	Dialoguing AI role: Respond with instances of data, summary themes, or direct responses		Include example prompts and responses
	Researcher role: Train with different sets of (potentially multi-modal) documents to understand cultural codes	Connecting AI role: Connect cultural discourses between datasets via automated coding		Note if process was one step or required AI training, role taking, etc.
	Researcher role: Triangulate findings that have been established through other methods	Corroborating AI role: Generate analysis to provide alternative and substantiating measures of textual data	Verisimilitude	For AI-generated materials, provide additional evidence from raw data or material
	Researcher role: Upload set of training data, known to the researcher (e.g., archival documents from endangered language)	Accessing AI role: Generate content dictionaries for comparative archival analysis		

Choosing an AI Assistant

Given the opportunities and challenges of collaborating with AI at different stages of the research process, researchers may also want to be mindful of which tool they choose (see [web appendix A](#) for a list of tools). Some tools like Claude may have a better writing style; some may more transparently provide underlying sources like Perplexity; and some, like ChatGPT, may be more adept at handling different types of data (e.g., video, audio, etc) or have superior reasoning skills. For example, one of our informants mentioned using Notebook during the research design phase to conduct the literature review, but then switching to LLaMa to analyze empirical datasets. Attributes like privacy protection (e.g., “walled” vs. un-“walled” assistants), the initial training dataset, the inclusion of sources alongside output, and the parameters for content selection may be equally important considerations when selecting a tool. Different hyperparameters—the “rules” put into place to structure the content that AI generates—may make some AI tools more apt than others for different research purposes ([Arnold et al. 2024](#); [Talamadupula 2024](#)). For example, one important hyperparameter is what AI researchers call “temperature,” the randomness of the output that the tool will produce. For idea generation, researchers may desire more randomness to produce more divergent ideas. For data analysis, however, researchers may want an AI with a “lower” temperature so that the tool will accurately reflect the data it was given. Other parameters like “frequency penalty” and “top probability” control the diversity of the language produced by the tool and may therefore be useful to consider when generating composite views from synthetic audiences.

CONCLUSION

Consumer culture theory has primarily developed with a researcher-as-instrument paradigmatic lens where the goal of analysis is a deep understanding that explains the cultural phenomenon under investigation. To this end, GenAI tools are only more efficient when they facilitate, rather than obfuscate, human sensemaking in the research process. The trade-offs we identify are meant to provide consumer culture researchers with a starting point for assessing what they gain and lose when collaborating with these tools.

There is also potential for consumer culture researchers to continue studying the norms, values, practices, and discourses that surround AI as a subject in its own right. Undoubtedly, prior work on the role of technological discourses in structuring consumer behavior ([Giesler 2008](#); [Kozinets 2008](#)), consumer creativity with technology ([Muñiz and Schau 2005](#)), its integration with consumer

practices ([Giesler 2006](#); [Kozinets, Patterson, and Ashman 2017](#)), and the legitimation of new technologies ([Mimoun, Trujillo-Torres, and Sobande 2022](#)) provides firm ground for making contributions to understanding how AI is integrated into consumer life and culture. We anticipate that, as the tools evolve, consumer culture researchers will find GenAI not only a fascinating object of research ([Huang and Rust 2025](#)) but also explore its potential for investigating new questions ([Puntoni, De Freitas, and Nave 2025](#)) and interacting with data in imaginative and productive ways.

DATA COLLECTION STATEMENT

Data were collected via video-conferencing platform between November 15, 2024, and February 15, 2025, by both authors. Both authors analyzed the data. Data are archived on the University of Wisconsin-Madison research drive and files are stored on both authors’ computers.

APPENDIX A

TABLE A1
PARTICIPANT PROFILES

Pseudonym	Research role	GenAI tools mentioned
Arya	Senior Research Mgr, Tech company	Copilot, Proprietary tools
Mia	Cultural Insights Analyst, Marketing Research Supplier	Proprietary tools
Nate	Cultural Insights Analyst, Marketing Research Supplier	Proprietary tools, ChatGPT, Claude, Elicit
Ash	Cultural Insights Analyst, Marketing Research Supplier	Proprietary tools, Copilot, Gemini, ChatGPT
Mattias	Academic researcher (CCT)	MAXQDA, Research Rabbit AI, Q-Insights, ChatGPT
Kathryn	Academic researcher (Sociology)	Gemma, LLaMa, LLMs
Maxime	Academic researcher (CCT)	ChatGPT
Serge	Academic researcher (text analysis)	LLMs
Valetta	Academic researcher (CCT—LLM text analysis)	MAXQDA, Perplexity AI
Jason	Academic researcher (CCT)	ChatGPT, LLaMa
Johann	Academic researcher (CCT)	ChatGPT to experiment; None for research—manual only

APPENDIX B

TABLE A2
DATA EXCERPTS

Reference ^a	Data	Participant
T1	"It's a tool for efficiency. . . We can be so much more productive in the way that we synthesize and analyze and aggregate our data points. I think putting interview transcripts through an LLM. . . and asking AI, 'what are the big points?'. . . You end up with these really high-level, chunky themes, and it means you're not going through the weeds of 35 pages of transcripts, highlighting and post-it notes, you know, it really kind of speeds up that whole process."	Ash, Industry Researcher
T2	"At the conceptualization stage. . . what is that definition? Or how does this idea differ from that? Or what is this theory about? Would it work differently? In place of this? It's [AI] become the partner in that conversation and trying to figure out puzzles with data and theory in real time." "You can probably do like 25 articles before it starts just giving you responses that aren't all that useful." . . . "you have to set it towards those micro tasks, and if you ask it to do too much at once, it just doesn't. It can't put it all together. . . As humans, we could see the micro, but we could also see the larger picture. . . It doesn't have that ability to work back and forth right now."	Jason, Academic Researcher
E1	"I would regard it [synthetic respondent] as a synthesis of whatever is the training data. . . It's not as a person, right? It's a synthesis of the discourse that is happening around whatever you're capturing in your training data. It's not representative. It's not anything that you would hear actually come out of the mouth of a real human in history. What these models are good at is they're synthesizing across a large amount of data. . . They capture schemas. Which is a concept we use a lot in cultural sociology. . . We do this all the time. We even do it in films, right? We create a composite character that's like a lot of different stories, but for dramatic purposes, we put them into one character. . . it's an ideal type. It's literally a synthetic thing."	Kathryn, Academic Researcher
E2	"One of my commitments is to ensure that the synthetic audience is built effectively [for the brand] But. . . I'm not doing that until I know what's under the hood. . . the thing with synthetic audiences is that they are only as good as the data. . . I want to make sure that data is comprehensive, that it's up to date. I just want to know what its perspective is based on, which is the research we fed into it, and that I do not know yet. . . We're trying to understand what are the use cases and we'll experiment."	Arya, Industry Researcher
E3	"With [Chat]GPT, we have no idea. No idea what's in them. And so now, I think we can't use them seriously as academics at all."	Kathryn, Academic Researcher
E4	"What we're looking for is idiosyncrasies and outliers and those interesting stories that can help brands or creative agencies think differently about their audience. . . those Aha! Those light bulb moments that completely challenge you and break down your [assumptions]. . . And if you're fabricating that stuff, you miss the magic. . . People don't make sense, and culture is incredibly messy. . . [using AI respondents] means that you miss some of the really fascinating things that are yet to come that you can only find by observing people in their home, or watching them in a moment of tension or engaging with communities in night-clubs or cafes. . . speaking to young people who are doing really interesting and cool stuff, none of which there is precedent for on the Internet. So where? Where can AI find that stuff? Which is why I think AI is a great tool, but it can't ever be the sole solution."	Ash, Industry Researcher
E5	"All of these models are trained on data. And so it's really, really critical the quality of the data that it's trained on. . . If they're unrepresented in the data, then how could we possibly imagine that we would like—I don't understand. . . To me it seems like just incredibly counter [intuitive]. . . underrepresented communities haven't even had a chance yet to have the complexity and nuance explored and revealed. . . that's a terrible place to start."	Arya, Industry Researcher
E6	"If I asked it. . . what would people say to a therapist? Well, it doesn't really observe what people say to therapists, or how therapists speak back to individuals. It could probably find examples of that, because people talk about pretty personal things in social media, you know, to each other and their online communities. But that might be different. . . And so my kind of overarching notion is that. . . Everything depends on the corpus that it's trained on. . . because until then we don't know how good it is. So for a thumb-to-the-wind test? Fine for generating human language. [But] if I'm a reviewer or an AE looking at a paper that their entire case is built on that, I'm going to look for more, for some human corroborating evidence."	Serge, Academic Researcher

TABLE A2 (CONTINUED)

Reference ^a	Data	Participant
E7	"Now, what we do know is these models—starting from topic models to word embedding models to the transformer revolution to large language models—we know what they do really well and the way social scientists use them is they embed all of the cultural and social biases that are there in language, right? This is how they're being used. What are gender stereotypes and how [have] they changed over the past 100 years? We use word embeddings to do that. . . . Because of the distributional hypothesis, they pick up on all of these cultural and social biases and relationships that are embedded in us as humans. . . . This is what makes them powerful. . . if we don't know the data that's in these models, we can't do what we as social scientists want to do which is use them to explain the underlying social system that produces them."	Kathryn, Academic Researcher
EP1	"If you've ever done a large-scale network analysis. . . you keep only the big nodes right? You literally just say all of the small stuff goes away. That's a choice we make. We don't have to do that. We can look at the small stuff, and that's what computational methods allow us to do. We can move the lens around and say no, actually we want to look at the small little pocket over here and there's enough data that we can do that because the data is so large. . . . So the fact that we have so much data, of course, it means that we could do it in a dumb way and pick up the dominant patterns and just say here's the major patterns. We don't have to. We can say no, we want the negative cases. We want the islands of difference. We want the weird thing that happens over here. . . . And then we can zoom back out and say that's how this weird little thing fits into the bigger picture. And so this ability to zoom in and out is exactly what computational methods allow us to do. Large language models are a little tricky because it all gets garbled into one thing right. So we have to approach it with a lot of care. There's no data provenance. There's no labels. We don't know who wrote what. So it gets a little bit tricky, and we have to be really careful now as we're approaching large language models not to allow these systems to get swamped by the dominant patterns. . . . We absolutely can train it and start to focus on negative cases and smaller things. . . . We can do whatever we want with them."	Kathryn, Academic Researcher
EP2	"[You] have a very quick look at how the machine synthesizes everything. . . . Sometimes it inspires you."	Valetta, Academic Researcher
EP3	"Our analysis depends on making observations. . . . What seems unusual. . . in what someone said? How someone said what they showed you in the explanation of something that was said? . . . That's what triggers, that becomes an analytic observation that I haven't seen a platform be able to deliver."	Mia, Industry Researcher
EP4	"We've got so many problems that we could be fixing with AI. Why are we focusing on this one? . . . It's a real skill to be able to moderate effectively to keep the clients' objectives top of mind, kind of analyzing as you go, reading the room, being empathetic to the participant, jumping around a discussion guide. . . . Any of the best qualitative researchers will write a discussion guide, and absolutely never follow it. Because you [are guided] by the participant, and I'm not sure yet how AI could do that effectively. And then, when it comes to actually being in the room with a participant and kind of observing cultural rituals, cultural moments, spending time with families over extended periods of time. You almost become an extended part of their world for a little while, and they trust you as custodians of their story."	Ash, Industry Researcher
H1	"[The Brysbaert concreteness dictionary] works well for contemporary data because it's trained on mostly contemporary data. . . . built by crowd workers today. . . . [But] we're talking about historical text, so that was a problem. . . . making this historical argument, it's not the best method that we could do because we really should be using historical stuff but we can't. . . . Words change meaning quite quickly right? 'Literally' doesn't mean now what it used to mean 10 years ago or 20 years ago. . . . The actual meaning has almost completely flipped. . . . so words change over time. . . . I would love to. . . . make a crowdsourced dictionary about concreteness scores from 1860. I think that's another use of these models."	Kathryn, Academic Researcher
H2	" . . . understanding the importance of culture on brands, and the idea that whether brands understand it or recognize it or not, culture exists. They are part of culture, and really that the success of a brand is tied to this idea of cultural relevance and their ability to understand the way that people are working and operating in their everyday life. . . . and the fact that culture is messy, and culture happens at the fringes and culture happens on the streets and in people's homes and is so embedded in behavior and rituals." (Ash)	Ash, Industry Researcher

^aT, theoretical; E, embodied; EP, empirical; H, historical.

APPENDIX C

GLOSSARY OF RESEARCHER-AI
COLLABORATIVE PRACTICES

Summarizing: Researchers use GenAI to summarize surface-level themes with a given set of empirical materials.

Limiting: Researchers use GenAI to summarize a theory or body of research from a given set of uploaded articles. While it may be possible to do this without uploading particular articles, our informants found that limiting the set produced more targeted, deeper summaries of the research.

Compositing: Researchers use GenAI to produce the response of a “typical” consumer that is a composite of previously entered materials, which may include interviews or archival documents such as message board chats or social media posts.

Extending: Researchers use GenAI to extend their embodied abilities (e.g., language barriers).

Querying: Researchers ask questions of AI to learn how the tool operates using its default training dataset at large.

Dialoguing: Researchers ask questions of data they have collected and uploaded using GenAI.

Connecting: Researchers use GenAI to connect cultural discourses between datasets. For example, one may feed in archival documents to train the tool and then have the tool suggest codes for an interview dataset.

Discovering: Researchers use GenAI to generate bottom-up analysis of data in order to discover new themes and to ensure that their interpretations represent overall themes.

Corroborating: Researchers use GenAI to triangulate findings that have been established through other methods. For example, researchers may use AI to assign codes to data that has also been coded by a human researcher or research assistant.

Accessing: Researchers ask the GenAI tool to access a perspective from a limited set of training data, known to the researcher (e.g., historical letters from 1880 to 1920, archival documents from endangered language).

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